

how to captivate his audience even when the camera is off. "Abhijat [Joshi] and I just sit and listen to him most of the time," says Hirani. "He is such a well-read guy. We have discussed everything under the sun, from cinema to sports to religion."

Some like Padukone, his co-star in four films, admire his perceptiveness (*see interview*). "He is extremely intelligent in terms of understanding people and relationships and extremely aware of his surroundings. He is sensitive to all of that."

MAKING OF AN ACTION HERO

While Khan is hailed and loved as the "king of romance", he actually loves action films. "He likes larger-than-life cinema," says an assistant director turned writer who worked with him. "For him, movies are magic, there has to be big drama, big-ticket stuff."

Post the failure of *Zero*, Khan set aside a year to meet filmmakers and hear the stories they had. Then Aditya Chopra called. The writer-director-producer finally acted on the promise he had made Khan three decades back: to offer him an action film. "When SRK was going through his tough phase, Adi was of the belief that whatever YRF is today has so much contribution from SRK that he felt it is his responsibility to at least try and make a big film for him," says Yash Raj Films CEO Akshaye Widhani. Chopra ended up making YRF's most expensive film to date. Khan was grateful for the chance that he was seeking. He also wasn't in a rush to finish any film.

PICTURE ABHI BAAKI HAI MERE DOST

The year 2023 has started on a bright note, but Khan is not even halfway through his comeback. He has two highly-anticipated releases lined up: *Jawan* and *Dunki* (see *Coming Soon...*). The year is all the more special because his daughter, Suhana, makes her debut in the Zoya Akhtar-directed feature *The Archies*, which releases on Netflix later this year. The 22-year-old has been prepping for it at least since 2014, maintaining a diary in which she records the many words of wisdom from her 'papa'. "Everything I don't know of acting, I have put it there for you to learn and teach me back, little one," replied Khan when she recently shared photos of it on Instagram.

Khan's eldest, Aryan, has kept a lower profile since the NCB saga. A graduate of the University of Southern California's School of Cinematic Arts, he has written a series, which Khan's banner, Red Chillies Entertainment, is producing. The youngest, nine-year-old AbRam, is the most doted on member of the family, witnessing his father's stardom as Khan stands on the balcony to strike his trademark pose. "He needs to see it like others have," Khan told the magazine. "So I have to work like that."

Working he is, so much so that public appearances have become few and far between. When he isn't shooting, he is on Twitter doing #AskSRK sessions expressing gratitude for the fans' love, and giving witty replies. Once a celebrity who embraced the spotlight, he now shies from it. Magazine covers don't matter. Our request for an interview was politely turned down. The reticence does not come from a loss of confidence. "I don't think I need to be nervous, I think they are all going to be superhit films," he said in Sharjah, when asked if he's anxious about his upcoming releases. "That's the belief I sleep and wake up with and which makes me at the age of 57 go and do stunts and work 18 hours a day." Coming from others, this assertion may sound pompous, but Khan makes it seem like he's letting you in on a secret or simply stating a fact.

Back at Land's End, as the decibel levels in the room grow louder and fans jostle for his attention, Khan tries to calm them down. "*Abhi jo waapis aaya hoon, kahin nahin jaa raha hoon* (Now that I am back, I am not going anywhere)." It has the opposite effect. They erupt. In joy. The Badshah in his darbar. ■